

Session 5: Tale of Two Seeds

Key Takeaways

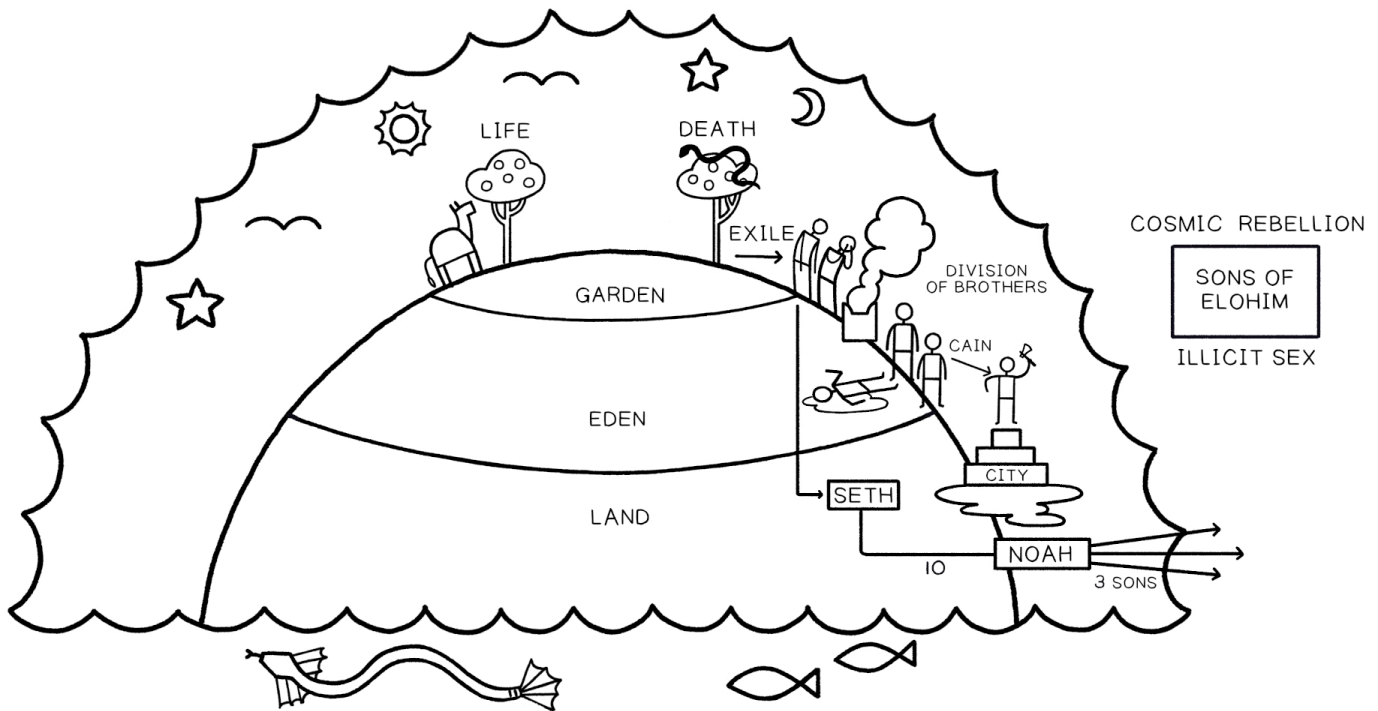
- It is not inevitable that Cain replays his parents' failure. Each generation faces its own testing.
- Genesis 4 and 5 gives us two genealogies, first Cain's and then Seth's—the seed of the snake and the seed of the woman. Cain starts off as the seed of the woman, but by his choices, he aligns himself with the seed of the snake.
- The continuation of Noah's genealogy in 6:9-10, 7:6, and 9:28-29 shows the seams where biblical authors wove two narratives into a unified story.

The Cycle of Themes in Genesis 1-11

Unit		Theme
A1	1:1-2:3 Creation of sacred cosmos from chaos waters / human image of God / blessing / fruitful and multiply	Creation and Blessing
B1	2:4-3:24 Mountain-garden temple / sin, nakedness, curse, exile	Failure
B2	4:1-16 Next generation sins / brothers divide / firstborn not chosen / curse, exile	Failure of Next Generation
C1	4:17-26 Adam to Lemek: 7 generations + 3 sons / city of Cain / murder / 70 x 7	Non-Chosen
C2	5:1-32 Adam to Noah: 10 generations + 3 sons / promise of comfort	Chosen
B3	6:1-8 Cosmic rebellion in Heaven and Earth: sons of God invade the land, leading to the flood	Cosmic Rebellion
A2	6:9-9:19 De-creation by chaos waters and recreation / Noah as new humanity / blessing / fruitful and multiply	Re-Creation and Blessing
Macro-Design of Genesis 1-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).		

Unit			Theme
	B1	9:20-21 Garden vineyard / sin, nakedness	Failure
	B2	9:22-27 Next generation sins / brothers divide / firstborn not chosen / curse, scattering	Failure of Next Generation
	C1	10:1-32 Noah + 3 sons / 7 generations to Peleg / City of Babylon and Assyria / 70 nations	Non-Chosen
	B3	11:1-9 Cosmic rebellion in Babylon: sons of Adam invade the heavens, leading to the scattering	Cosmic Rebellion
	C2	11:10-26 Shem to Abram: 10 generations / 3 sons	Chosen
A3		12:1-9 Abram as new humanity / blessing / fruitful and multiply	Re-Creation and Blessing
Macro-Design of Genesis 1-11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).			

Genesis 5:1-32: Ten Generations From Adam to Noah



From Adam to Noah's Three Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

After the humans are exiled from Eden, and after the drama of election that splits Adam and Eve's family into two lines, the narrative reboots and begins again. This time, the genealogy follows the line of Seth, Cain's line having been concluded with Lemek and sons. This genealogy has a highly schematic form, which makes the three "narrative inserts" stick out.

Literary Design of Each Generation

This genealogy lists ten generations from Adam to Noah. Each one is given in an identical literary form:

And ___ lived ___ years, and he caused the birth of [son's name].

And ___ lived ___ years after he caused the birth of [sons' name], and he caused the birth of sons and daughters,

and all the days of ___ were ___ years,

and he died.

Three Special People in Genesis 5

There are three figures whose genealogical entry deviates from this form, and at precisely these three points we find narrative inserts that highlight important themes of Genesis. Pay special attention to Adam, Enoch, and Lemek/Noah.

¹ This is the scroll of the generations of **Adam** ;
In the day when Elohim created **humanity** ,
he made him as the likeness of Elohim,
male and female he created them,
and he blessed them
and he named them **'human'**
in the day when they were created.

10 Generations

Adam

³ And Adam had lived one hundred and thirty years,
and he caused the birth of one

in his own likeness ,
according to his image ,
and named him Seth .

⁴ And the days of Adam after he caused the birth of Seth were eight hundred years,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

⁵ And all the days that Adam lived were nine hundred and thirty years,
and he died.

Seth

⁶ And Seth lived one hundred and five years,
and he caused the birth of Enosh.

⁷ And Seth lived eight hundred and seven years after he caused the birth of Enosh,
and he he caused the birth of sons and daughters,

⁸ and all the days of Seth were nine hundred and twelve years,
and he died.

Enosh

⁹ And Enosh lived ninety years,
and he caused the birth of Cainan.

¹⁰ And Enosh lived eight hundred and fifteen years after he caused the birth of Cainan,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

¹¹ And all the days of Enosh were nine hundred and five years,
and he died.

Cainan

¹² And Cainan lived seventy years,
and he caused the birth of Mahalalel.

¹³ And Cainan lived eight hundred and forty years after he he caused the birth of Mahalalel,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

¹⁴ And all the days of Cainan were nine hundred and ten years,

and he died.

Mahalalel

¹⁵ And Mahalalel lived sixty-five years,
and he caused the birth of Jared.

¹⁶ And Mahalalel lived eight hundred and thirty years after he became the father of Jared,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

¹⁷ And all the days of Mahalalel were eight hundred and ninety-five years,
and he died.

Yared

¹⁸ And Yared lived one hundred and sixty-two years,
and he caused the birth of Enoch.

¹⁹ And Yared lived eight hundred years after he became the father of Enoch,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

²⁰ And all the days of Yared were nine hundred and sixty-two years,
and he died.

Enoch

²¹ And Enoch lived sixty-five years,
and he caused the birth of Methuselah,

²² and Enoch **walked with God three hundred years**
after he became the father of Methuselah,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters,

²³ and all the days of Enoch were three hundred and sixty-five years,

²⁴ **and Enoch walked with God ;**
and he was not, for God took him .

Methuselah

²⁵ And Methuselah lived one hundred and eighty-seven years,
and he became the father of Lemek,

²⁶ and Methuselah lived seven hundred and eighty-two years after he became the father of Lemek,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

²⁷ And all the days of Methuselah were nine hundred and sixty-nine years,
and he died.

Lemek

²⁸ And Lemek lived one hundred and eighty-two years,
and he caused the birth of a son,

²⁹ **and he called his name "Noah," saying,**
"This one will give us rest from our work
and from the toil of our hands from the ground
which the Lord has cursed."

²⁰ And Lemek lived five hundred and ninety-five years after he became the father of Noah,

and he caused the birth of sons and daughters,
³¹ and all the days of Lemek were seven hundred and seventy-seven years,
and he died.

Noah

³² And Noah was five hundred years old,
and Noah he caused the birth of Shem, Ham, and Japheth ...

Genesis 5:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

Why Enoch, the Seventh From Adam?

Of the three characters with a special narrative insert in the genealogy of Genesis 5, we have the least information about Enoch. But the information we do have connects him to significant themes within the early chapters of Genesis.

- “Enoch” (חֲנוֹךְ) means “dedicated” in Hebrew. The word is used as a verb in Deuteronomy 20:5 and 1 Kings 8:63, which are both about dedicating a house or temple.
- Enoch’s total age surely has symbolic significance: 365 years is the same as a solar calendar year.
- Enoch’s piety is linked to that of Adam and Eve’s in the garden of Eden and sets a pattern for later characters to attain.

Genesis 3:6, 8 NASB*

... and [Eve] took (לָקַח) from its fruit and she ate ...

... and [Adam and Eve] heard the voice of Yahweh walking (מִתְהַלֵּךְ) in the garden.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 5:22, 24 NASB*

... and Enoch walked (וַיִּתְהַלֵּךְ) with the-Elohim ...

... and Enoch walked (וַיִּתְהַלֵּךְ) with the-Elohim, and he was not, because Elohim took (לָקַח) him.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

What Does it Mean to “Walk With God?”

The phrase “walk with God” is used of Noah in Genesis 6:8-9. In 1 Samuel 25:15-16, the phrase is used to refer to friendly and close contact between people.

Genesis 6:8-9 NASB

⁸ But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD. ⁹ These are the records of the generations of Noah. **Noah was a righteous man, blameless in his time; Noah walked with God.**

1 Samuel 25:14-16 NASB

¹⁴ But one of the young men told Abigail, Nabal's wife, saying, "Behold, David sent messengers from the wilderness to greet our master, and he scorned them. ¹⁵ Yet the men were very good to us, and we were not insulted, nor did we miss anything as long as **we walked with them**, while we were in the fields. ¹⁶ They were a wall to us both by night and by day, all the time we were with them tending the sheep."

"[T]he meaning of the phrase ... is obvious from 1 Samuel 25:15-16, where it describes friendly everyday conduct with regard to one's neighbors. The [author of Genesis 5] understood the words in the sense that Enoch stood in a direct and immediate relationship to God ... and so was entrusted with God's plans and intentions. This is the starting point for the significance that the figure of Enoch had in a tradition that began early and reached its fullness only in the Apocalyptic literature."

Westermann, Claus (1990). [*Genesis 1-11 \(Continental Commentary\)*](#). Fortress Press. 358.

"With The-Elohim"

Although it is not reflected in English, the word *elohim* in 5:22 and 5:24 has the definite article "the" in front of it (האלהים). The phrase "the-*elohim*" can be used to refer to the single deity Yahweh, and it can also refer to spiritual beings, members of the divine council, or angels (see [Ps. 8:6](#); [82:1, 6](#); [97:7](#); [138:1](#)).

Notice also that in the phrase "for God took him," the word *Elohim* does not have the definite article (כי לקח אתו אלהים). In other words, Enoch walks with the-*elohim* and so *Elohim* takes him.

This distinction seems like an intended and meaningful one: Enoch's life was marked by his friendly and intimate relations with the beings of the spiritual realm (the-*elohim*), and so the chief *Elohim* (named "Yahweh" later in the story) takes him.

This was how the story was universally understood in ancient Judaism (see 1 Enoch, or 2 Enoch).

"And He Was Not, Because God Took Him."

In the middle of a genealogy that focuses on death as the sad curtain closer on God's blessing for life, Enoch's evasion of death in the seventh generation stands out. He is marked as the seventh (= complete) human whose allegiance and union with God results in eternal life.

The word "took" (לקח) is a back reference to [Genesis 2:15](#), where God "took" the human he had created and "rested" (wordplay on Noah's name: וינחהו) him in the garden. Enoch is set on analogy to the human of Genesis 2, that is, Enoch is transferred to the garden of Eden, the realm of eternal life. This is how the earliest interpretation of the Enoch story goes as preserved in 1 Enoch chapters 24-32, where Enoch is taken up in the Spirit and tours the cosmos until he arrives in Eden, the mountain of God.

Notice that the phrase is repeated in 5:22 and in 5:24, which speaks of his "removal." This indicates that Enoch's intimacy with the-*elohim* marked both his 365 years and his translation to another realm.

In a later story modeled after Enoch's divine disappearance, Elijah's departure happens in a similar way and with similar vocabulary.

2 Kings 2:9-11 NASB

⁹ When they had crossed over, Elijah said to Elisha, “Ask what I shall do for you before **I am taken** from you.” And Elisha said, “Please, let a double portion of your spirit be upon me.” ¹⁰ He said, “You have asked a hard thing. Nevertheless, if you see me **when I am taken** from you, it shall be so for you; but if not, it shall not be so.” ¹¹ As they were going along and talking, behold, there appeared a chariot of fire and horses of fire which separated the two of them. And **Elijah went up in a storm to the heavens**.

Psalm 49:15 NASB*

But God will redeem my soul from the power of the grave,
for **he will take me**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The parallels between Adam and Enoch’s being “taken” to Eden where they “walk with God” and the later design pattern of Elijah’s departure suggest that Enoch is taken to Eden, the cosmic mountain in the skies. This is the primary image of “the heavens” where God’s space and human space are one. This is also how Enoch is portrayed in Jewish literature outside the Hebrew Bible (see 1 Enoch 14, 71 and 2 Enoch).

Noah as the Promised Comforter of Humanity in Genesis 5

Every line of Lemek’s words have significant hyperlinks back to various texts in Genesis 1-3.

The Naming of Noah	Hyperlinks to Earlier Verses in Genesis
Genesis 5:29: And he called his name “ Noah (נח),” saying, “This one will give us comfort (נחם) from our work (מעשה) and from the painful toil (מעצבון) of our hands, from the ground (האדמה) which the Lord has cursed (אררה).”	Genesis 2:15: And Yahweh <i>Elohim</i> took the human and he rested him (וינחהו) in the garden of Eden, to work it (עבד) and to keep it. Genesis 3:17-19: Cursed is the ground (ארורה האדמה) because of you, with painful toil (עצבון) you will eat from it ... until you return to the ground (האדמה), for from it you were taken ... Genesis 3:23: And Yahweh <i>Elohim</i> sent him out from the garden of Eden to work (עבד) the ground (האדמה) from which he was taken ...
<i>The Naming of Noah</i> . Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Lemek’s anticipation of a future descendant who will bring an end to the curse picks up the macro themes of (1) humanity’s exile from Eden and the curse of death and (2) the promise of a coming “seed” who will overcome the snake.

“Noah” (נח) / “rest” (נוח) / “comfort” (נחם): Noah’s name is spelled like the word “rest,” and it rhymes with the first two letters of the word “comfort.”

Through this connection to rest, Noah’s role in the story is previewed and given a theological interpretation. God brings rest and comfort to his world through Noah’s obedient actions and role as the surviving remnant in the flood generation.

Rest (נוח) is a major theological theme in the TaNaK for describing the restoration of Eden conditions on Earth as in Heaven. When God brings rest, it involves restoring a realm of order and sacred space where God can dwell with his people (see Deut. 3:20, 12:10; Josh. 1:13, 21:44; 2 Sam. 7:1, 11; 1 Kgs. 5:18).

Comfort (נחם) is a major theme in the Prophets, especially in Isaiah, and it describes the era of restoration when the failure of God’s people is forgiven, their exile is over, and God renews his covenant with them in a restored Eden.

This points forward to Noah’s crucial act of worship and obedience as he emerges from the ark in Genesis 8:20-22. In the narrative arc of Genesis 2-9, Noah is placed before the reader as an image of the promised seed of Genesis 3:15.

Noah is the righteous seed who passes the test through obedience to God’s will, and he survives as a remnant through the waters of death to offer a precious sacrifice. This qualifies him to become the new humanity at the helm of a renewed creation that lives in a new covenant relationship with its creator.

Introduction to the Flood Narrative in Genesis 6:1-9:27

The flood narrative spans from Genesis 6:1 to Genesis 9:27, and it consists of 15 large literary units made of narrative and poetic materials. The flood narrative has been spliced into the end of Noah’s genealogy, which is now split into two parts in 5:32 and 9:28-29.

It also seems likely that 6:9-10 and 7:6 are a continuation of the genealogy in 5:32 and the natural bridge to the information in 9:28-29, which presents Noah’s total age at 958 years.

Topic	Verses
Genealogy Begins	Genesis 5:21-31 ²⁸ And Lemek lived one hundred and eighty-two years, and became the father of a son. ²⁹ Now he called his name Noah, saying, “This one will give us rest from our work and from the toil of our hands arising from the ground which the LORD has cursed.” ³⁰ And Lemek lived five hundred and ninety-five years after he became the father of Noah, and he had other sons and daughters. ³¹ So all the days of Lemek were seven hundred and seventy-seven years, and he died.
Genealogy with Flood Narrative Inserted. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Topic		Verses
		And Noah was five hundred years old, and Noah became the father of Shem, Ham, and Japheth ...
	Flood Narrative Begins	Genesis 6:1-8 ¹ When human beings began to increase in number on the earth and daughters were born to them ...
	Genealogy Inserted	Genesis 6:9-10 ⁹ These are the birth-generations of Noah; Noah was a righteous one, blameless in his generation; Noah walked with <i>Elohim</i> ; ...
	Flood Narrative Continues	Genesis 6:11-7:5 ¹¹ Now the earth was corrupt in the sight of God, and the earth was filled with violence ...
	Genealogy Inserted	Genesis 7:6 ... and Noah was six hundred years old when the flood of water came upon the earth ...
	Flood Narrative Ends	Genesis 7:7-9:27 ^{9:27} ... May God enlarge Japheth, and may he live in the tents of Shem; and may Canaan be his servant."
	Genealogy Ends	Genesis 9:28-29 ²⁸ ... And Noah lived after the flood, three hundred and fifty years after the flood. ²⁹ And all the days of Noah were nine hundred and fifty years, and he died.
Genealogy with Flood Narrative Inserted. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).		

The arrangement of the text gives a clue to its meaning. The flood narrative is a long exposition of Lemek's promise in Genesis 5:29, which itself recalls God's promise in [Genesis 3:15-17](#). Noah is presented as the promised seed of the woman who will undo the curse. The question is, How? The flood narrative is designed to provide the answer.

Reflection Question

Since Adam and Eve had already sinned, do you think the sins of their children, such as Cain murdering Abel, were unavoidable?